

SPI 387: Education Policy

Week 4 Precept

Other SPI 387 Precepts

- Tuesdays, 9:35am-10:25am
 - Robertson 012
 - Taught by me (vn0096@princeton.edu)
- Tuesdays, 9:35am-10:25am
 - Robertson 035
 - Taught by Varsha (vm3529@princeton.edu)
- Tuesdays, 3:30pm-4:20pm
 - Robertson 020
 - Taught by Dr. Jennings (jlj@princeton.edu)
- Thursdays, 9:35am-10:25am
 - Robertson 035
 - Taught by Varsha (vm3529@princeton.edu)

This Week's Readings

- Supreme Court of the United States. (1954). *Brown v. Board of Education of Topeka*, 347 U.S. 483 (1954).
- Bell, D. (2004). *The unintended lessons in Brown v. Board of Education*. New York Law School Law Review, 49(4), 1053–1069.
- Supreme Court of the United States. (1982). *Plyler v. Doe*, 457 U.S. 202 (1982).
- Hannah-Jones, N. (2016, June 9). *Choosing a school for my daughter in a segregated city*. The New York Times Magazine.

Brown v. Board of Education (1954)

- Struck down “*separate but equal*” — segregated schools unconstitutional
- Found: “Separate educational facilities are inherently unequal”
- Mandated desegregation, but gave no roadmap for integration
 - Desegregation = ending “white-only” schools
 - Integration = creating inclusive, diverse learning environments
- Court referenced Kenneth Clark’s doll studies → segregation harms children’s self-image
- Landmark case: victory in principle, but left struggle for true integration to the future

Derrick Bell, “The Unintended Lessons of Brown v. Board of Education (2005)

- Interest Convergence: Brown passed because segregation hurt America’s Cold War image, not mainly because of harm to Black children.
- Harm ≠ Change: Racial injustice alone rarely drives reform; change comes when white/national interests are at stake.
- Who Benefits?: Whites often benefit most from civil rights policies; “color-blind” rulings let society deny ongoing racial disparities.
- Negative Consequences: Brown led to Black school closures, firing of Black teachers, hostile environments, and non-academic tracking for Black students.

Re: Bell and Brown v. BoE

Taking into consideration what Bell discusses in his piece about the interest motivation for Brown as well as how the desegregation mandate ultimately affected Black students, what do we think ought to be the intended outcome of desegregating schools? Try to frame your answers using the Brighthouse framework.

Plyler v. Doe (1982)

Plaintiff's Claim

- Class action against Tyler ISD (Texas) after it charged tuition to undocumented children
- Based on a 1975 law that cut state funds to schools enrolling undocumented students

Court's Ruling

- 5-4 decision: States cannot deny school access based on immigration status
- Equal Protection Clause of the 14th Amendment applies to undocumented children
- Schools cannot ask about immigration status at enrollment

Why It Matters

- Unique ruling: Few countries guarantee free education to undocumented children
- Establishes a “floor”: all children must have access to basic schooling
- But does not guarantee equal quality or resources to address disadvantage

Nikole Hannah-Jones, “Choosing a School for My Daughter in a Segregated City” (2016)

- Chose P.S. 307 (mostly Black/Latino) instead of “better” white schools
- Rezoning from overcrowded P.S. 8 sparked white parent backlash → racial undertones
- Argues: true integration requires privileged families to share schools
- Risk: integration often flips into resegregation
- Takeaway: Segregation today persists through housing + parental choice; equity needs shared sacrifice

Re: Hanna-Jones

What seems to be the tradeoff for parents to enroll their children in a segregated school vs an integrated school? Again, try to frame this using the terms in the Brighthouse framework.

Most of you *probably* think we should aim to have integrated schools. How do we convince opposing families to support efforts for integration (such as rezoning, redistribution of students, etc)?

Exit Ticket

Let us know how we can design next week's precept to make you all feel more comfortable with the material as the midterm approaches. This could be anything like reviewing specific content from previous weeks content (though we will also cover week 5 readings), a specific type of exercise you'd like to do, etc.